



by *Islam* in the seventh century. Although most of the people who identify themselves as Persians today are Muslim, a small number in Iran and elsewhere still observe this religion. They believe in one God, *Abura Mazda*, who

created the world and whose sacred symbol is fire, representing the triumph of light over darkness. *Abura Mazda* is in perpetual conflict with the force of evil, who is known as *Angra Mainyu*.



ENJOYING THE SPRING WEATHER

On *Sizdah Bedar*—the 13th and final day of *Nowruz*—it is considered bad luck to stay indoors so people go for a festive picnic in the countryside. Some people take a small pot of sprouting grain, planted some weeks earlier, and toss it into running water or plant it to signify the start of a new agricultural year.



GOLDFISH FOR THE NEW YEAR

Seven items—the *haft sin* (see below)—are displayed in honor of *Nowruz* in Persian homes. Other objects such as candles, a mirror, a copy of the *Avesta*, and goldfish in a bowl may also be laid out.

A HOLY PLACE

More than half of the world's 200,000 Zoroastrians live in Iran. Every year, pilgrims gather for a five-day pilgrimage to one of Zoroastrianism's most sacred sites, the mountain temple at Chakchak in southern Iran. The entrance to the temple displays the cardinal principles of their faith—"Good Thoughts, Good Words, Good Deeds."



THE SEVEN Ss

A festive table of items called the *haft sin* might consist of *seer* (garlic), *seeb* (apple), *serkeh* (vinegar), *samanu* (a sweet made of wheat shoots), *sombol* (hyacinth), *sekeh* (a gold coin), and *somagh* (sumac).

